lack of follow-up action on the part of SSNCo's agents too cannot be discounted—many of them were volunteers and amateurs. Whatever the reason, full payment for the shares had not been received. In this situation, the directors even considered declaring such shares forfeit to the company.

While the compulsions behind the idea of forfeiture are understandable, it would have only been counterproductive. The company's primary asset was goodwill and it would have taken a beating, damaging the morale not only of current and future shareholders, but the general public. Did the company take this decision? This was unlikely, for the company was too weak to take such a drastic step. If it had, the resultant protests could not have gone unnoticed. In sum, unpaid calls on subscribed shares continued to plague the company until the last.



Who were the shareholders and what was their geographical spread? In April, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar stated that, apart from Madras Presidency, shareholders came from Bengal, Bombay and also from Natal in South Africa and Ceylon.[130]

The news from Madras City was not good: according to *The Hindu* only twenty-seven persons in the city had taken shares—numbering a pathetic 228 shares. The corresponding figures for Bombay were 274 persons and 954 shares, and for Calcutta, 369 and 1209.[131] In keeping with his political position, as a follower of Tilak, Bharati blamed the hypocrisy of the Madras moderates who only paid lip service to patriotism but dared not loosen their purse strings.[132] Further taunting the moderates, he said, this effort fell squarely within Lord Minto's definition of 'honest swadeshi' untainted by 'boycott' and yet they had let down an institution of such significance.[133]

According to the SSNCo's Colombo agent, as of September, 'the number of shares sold so far as Ceylon is concerned is 2930'.[134] A well-informed 'Galle-nesan' gave a figure of 3,000 shares after talking to some SSNCo's directors in Colombo.[135] Most of these shares were taken by merchants from Tuticorin—mostly Vellalar, Nattukkottai Chettiar and Muslim—who